

PRESS BRIEFING REPORT

Sister Guardians Initiative: A Beacon of Hope for Survivors of Gender-Based Violence

In the community of Affa-Amozolla, Enugu State, Nigeria, a devastating case of rape shook the lives of a 16-year-old girl and her family. The trauma and stigma associated with rape threatened to derail their lives forever. But fortunately, there was a beacon of hope - the Sister Guardians Initiative (SGI).

Established by the South Saharan Social Development Organisation (SSDO), the SGI is a community-based intervention operating in about 24 communities in Enugu State and Anambra State, that provides a safe space for women and girls to report cases of GBV and receive comprehensive support. The initiative is made up of trained community volunteers, known as Sister Guardians, who offer emotional support, counseling, and referrals to medical and legal services.

For the young rape survivor, the SGI was a lifeline. The Sister Guardians provided a non-judgmental space for her to share her experience and receive support. They connected her with medical services to address her physical and emotional needs and helped her family cope with the trauma. They also ensured that she went back to school, paid her fees and gave her back-to-school items. All these interventions ensured that she was reintegrated back into society, illustrating the transformative impact of community-driven support systems.

The SGI's impact extends beyond individual cases, contributing to a broader cultural shift in the communities where they operate. By promoting a culture of zero tolerance for GBV and providing support to survivors, the SGI is helping create safer, more equitable communities for all.

As a follow-up to the SGI's intervention in the case of the 16-year-old girl, SSDO commemorated International Women's Day (IWD) 2025 at Affa-Amozolla Community Secondary School. The theme of this year's IWD was "For All Women and Girls: Rights, Equality, and Empowerment." The event included a workshop focused on human rights and gender abuse, which aimed to equip participants with knowledge on recognizing GBV, understanding its various forms, and accessing support systems.

The training was conducted by resource persons, including a Lawyer who highlighted the legal framework that protects women and girls in Nigeria, and a gender representative from TARMA-SARC who explained the definition and types of GBV, as well as reporting mechanisms.

The introduction of the SGI representatives during the training established a direct link between the community and the SGI, providing a trusted and accessible support system for survivors of GBV. The training was well-received by the community, with the school principal expressing deep appreciation for the initiative.

The SSDO and SGI continue to work together to promote a culture of zero tolerance for GBV and provide support to survivors. Their dedication and compassion are making a tangible difference in the lives of women and girls across Enugu and Anambra States.

As we reflect on the SGI's remarkable work, we are reminded that every woman and girl deserves to live a life free from violence and discrimination. The Sister Guardians Initiative is a shining example of what can be achieved when communities come together to support survivors of GBV.